Clyde Hendrickson's

# *Mother-Daughter Dialogues*

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Be nice to your family.

Clyde Hendrickson's

# *Mother-Daughter Dialogues*

Scenes to be played on a blank stage.
Actors playing mother & daughter do not age over the course of the play.

***nine-years old.***

MEGHAN. Mom, when you and dad got married, did you give him The BJ?

MOTHER. WHAT?

MEGHAN. My friend Mikala said on their wedding nights, the Moms give the Dads the BJ.

MOTHER. Meghan, I don't... You shouldn't... ask your father.

MEGHAN. Ok.

MOTHER. Wait! On second thought, just go to your room and pray.

***twelve-years old.***

MEGHAN. Mom, can I be president when I grow up?

MOTHER. Oh honey, sure.

MEGHAN. Really?

MOTHER. Well, maybe. Society will have to change.

MEGHAN. So a girl can be president?

MOTHER. So a fat girl can be president!

MEGHAN. Oh. So I just have to get thin?

MOTHER. And work hard in school, etc. But thin is most important.

MEGHAN. Alright, I'll try harder.

MOTHER. I know you will. Your Dad & I believe in you.

MEGHAN. Thanks, you're the best!

*keeping tabs.*

MEGHAN. Hi Mom!

MOTHER. Did you get taller?

++

MEGHAN. Hey Mom!

MOTHER. Did you get fatter?

MEGHAN. Since the last time you saw me?

MOTHER. How many of those meringues did you eat?

++

MEGHAN. Hi, I'm home from camp!

MOTHER. Look how much you've grown.

++

MEGHAN. I'm back from Becky's sleepover

MOTHER. Look how much your thighs have grown.

MEGHAN. I was only gone for 12 hours…

*prom date.*

MEGHAN. Can you wear red to prom?

MOTHER. Might lead to some fire truck jokes.

MEGHAN. Mom!

MOTHER. Only because it's so bright, dear.

MEGHAN. James likes red.

MOTHER. I'm sure James won't care after his forth vodkatini.

MEGHAN. We're not gonna drink.

MOTHER. That's not what the bottle of Olde English I found under your bed says.

MEGHAN. I couldn't even finish it, it was gross. It tasted like bums were fighting in my mouth.

MOTHER. Let's hope James is as discriminating.

MEGHAN. Oooh! How about this one!

MOTHER. Lavender is a whore color.

MEGHAN. That's like the 50th dress you've shot down for making me look promiscuous. I could wear a pantsuit.

MOTHER. You should follow my advice. Remember when I warned you not to wear white to Wet & Wild? But you never listen to me.

MEGHAN. Maybe that's because all you ever say is that I'm a disappointment and, and you're always comparing my thighs to Tina Turner's head.

MOTHER. The truth hurts.

MEGHAN. I might have a bit of cottage cheese, fine, but I think there are more truths to me than that.

MOTHER. We'll see.

MEGHAN. I really, really want this dress.

MOTHER. You're not getting it. What about that one?

MEGHAN. Mom, it has lace. I'd look like a table setting. What is wrong with you?

MOTHER. Let's go to Sears, they're having a sale.

MEGHAN. You know what? You can go without me. I'll wear whatever you pick out, since you always know what's best.

MOTHER. That's the smartest thing you've said in a while.

*watch what you eat.*

MOTHER. Meghan! Meghan, it's almost time to go. James will be here any minute.

MEGHAN. I'll be out in a second.

MOTHER. You've been in there 10 minutes!

MEGHAN. No, Mom, I – don't come in…

MOTHER. What is that smell? Were you throwing up? Are you ok?

MEGHAN. I'm fine.

MOTHER. If you're sick you can't go to prom. Are you pregnant?

MEGHAN. No mom, I am NOT pregnant.

MOTHER. Just nerves. We'll get you some Sprite. FRANK BRING MEGHAN A SPRITE. SHE'S BEEN PUKING.

MEGHAN. Lovely. Just lovely. I'm fine.

MOTHER. Why were you throwing up?

MEGHAN. It was… well…

MOTHER. Wait, were you…

MEGHAN. Don't ask.

MOTHER. Were you purging?

MEGHAN. Just a little. To fit into this old dress.

MOTHER. Why would you do that? Was it something you read on the internets?

MEGHAN. No…

MOTHER. Your friends pressured you? That Mikala, she's too thin anyway.

MEGHAN. No. It was you.

MOTHER. Don't be ridiculous. You know I love you just the way you are. FRANK WE NEED SPRITE AND SOME SALTINES.

MEGHAN. And some earplugs. Do you really like me the way I am?

MOTHER. You're going to be a very beautiful woman.

MEGHAN. You think so.

MOTHER. Let's get you out of that old dress.

MEGHAN. But I'm still going.

MOTHER. I know, I know, but not in that.

MEGHAN. What do you mean?

MOTHER. I bought you the dress you liked.

MEGHAN. The lavender one?

MOTHER. Yes. You did look stunning in it.

MEGHAN. Thanks.

MOTHER. A stunning prostitute, but still… radiant. You are a lovely girl.

MEGHAN. You should try and say that more often.

MOTHER. Don't blame me for everything.

MEGHAN.

*first visit to college.*

MOTHER. So this is your dorm room. Where's the Patrick Swayze poster I bought you? He looked so good in that Speedo.

MEGHAN. It uh… got lost… or, uh… I gave it… to, uh, charity. This little orphan girl that loved Dirty Dancing

MOTHER. How's everything? How's school?

MEGHAN. Fine. I have a lot of work.

MOTHER. How are *you*?

MEGHAN. I'm ok…

MOTHER. Are you sure – you sound funny.

MEGHAN. Mom, I'm fine, just stressed, and tired.

MOTHER. You sound pregnant.

MEGHAN. Mom, no – what?

MOTHER. Are you tired and groggy because you're pregnant? That's what it sounds like.

MEGHAN. Mom, I haven't even dated a guy, much less slept – oh my god this is SO none of your business.

MOTHER. Young lady, you know it's my business. Now you know you're too young to be having a child.

MEGHAN. Mom, no one is having a child. I am not pregnant.

MOTHER. (Weeping) I just worry so much about your decisions. I want you to be happy.

MEGHAN. We agree on this Mom, really, we do.

MOTHER. I hope so. (sniffing) I hope so.

MEGHAN. No babies!

MOTHER. Never? How could you say that?

MEGHAN. I didn't mean never… no, you just said you didn't want me…

MOTHER. You don't think I'd be a good grandmother?

MEGHAN. You'd be a great grandmother! I'll have a million little adorable babies for you to cuddle, ok?

MOTHER. Alright, but not until you're married.

MEGHAN. Oh my god.

(*Mom is opening drawers*)

MEGHAN. What are you looking for?

MOTHER. Condoms.

MEGHAN. I don't have any condoms! I'm not… I don't need them.

MOTHER. You're not going to use a condom?

MEGHAN. No, no, I… fine, look, there are some in the bathroom. (She points)

MOTHER. (*looks*) You better not use these.

MEGHAN. But, I'm not.

MOTHER. Then why do you have them?

MEGHAN. I wonder if it's too late to transfer to a school that's out of state.

MOTHER. Maybe to an all-girls school.

MEGHAN. Anyway. I'm thinking of being a social worker. I love this sociology class I'm in. The Professor, Dr. Bryant, he used to work in Port-au-Prince –

MOTHER. Oh no. Just because you have a crush on some hippy professor you are not going to throw your life away. Or this expensive education. You're going to be a doctor, a lawyer or own a chain of grocery stores.

MEGHAN. But social work is what I want to do. *You* said I could do whatever I want.

MOTHER. Meg, just because you are *able* to do anything you want doesn't mean you *can* do anything you want.

MEGHAN. That doesn't make any sense, Mom.

MOTHER. It makes perfect sense to me. You can do anything you like, as long as I approve.

*One other thing…*

(*on the phone*)

MEGHAN. What's up mom.

MOTHER. I can't find the phone.

MEGHAN. You're on the phone.

MOTHER. My cell, I mean, I can't find it.

MEGHAN. I'm 1200 miles away. How would I know?

MOTHER. You have to help your mother when she needs you.

MEGHAN. Ok…

MOTHER. Guess.

MEGHAN. Did you leave it in the linen closet, like last time?

MOTHER. No, I checked. The pool filter too.

MEGHAN. Did you throw it away? You once threw away the television remote.

MOTHER. I guess I'll have to rummage through the trash barrel later.

MEGHAN. Man, I miss all the good stuff being away.

MOTHER. Haha. Oh, that reminds me, your cat died.

MEGHAN. WHAT?

MOTHER. Yes, Mr. Skittles' thyroid finally caught up to him. We put him to sleep this morning.

MEGHAN. Why didn't you mention that first?

MOTHER. That seems cruel. To just call you up and say "Guess what, your cat died."

MEGHAN. The small talk did not make it any better.

MOTHER. I tried. I tried.

MEGHAN. Did you leave your cellphone at the vet?

MOTHER. Oh! You know I think I did.

MEGHAN. Poor Mr. Skittles.

MOTHER. We'll miss him.

MEGHAN. He hated you, you know.

MOTHER. But he paid attention to me. And that is rare in this house.

MEGHAN. I wonder why. Poor Mr. Skittles… I gotta go tell Steve.

MOTHER. Your boyfriend never met Mr. Skittles.

MEGHAN. But he is capable of empathy. Unlike some people.

MOTHER. Well tell Steve I said "Sorry about Mr. Skittles" then.

MEGHAN. Thanks, I will.

*many blessings.*

(*On the phone*)

MEGHAN. Mom, I have big news.

MOTHER. Ooooh, what is it, honey?

MEGHAN. It's about Steve.

MOTHER. Oh no. Did he have a secret baby out of wedlock, and now the mother is trying to kill you both?

MEGHAN. Wow. Did you get that from *Law & Order*, Lifetime or just your old batty Republican friends?

MOTHER. You know I still have the number of Barry Steinman's son. He's at Yale Law.

MEGHAN. I am not dating Dick Steinman! He's 5'2" and he smells like fish all the time.

MOTHER. You shouldn't judge based on looks. Or odor. That's a disorder called Trimethylaminuria.

MEGHAN. How do you know these things? Dick Steinman smells like fish because he doesn't bathe and he eats a jar of pickles every day. Besides, I don't need Pickle Dick's number because Steve and I are getting married.

MOTHER. (*gasps*) Oh, Meghan!

MEGHAN. I know, I'm so happy!

MOTHER. That is so wonderful, I'm – Oh no, you can't get married!

MEGHAN. Why not?

MOTHER. You'll never fit into a dress, dear. Oh Steve was so nice to ask, really, what a sweet fellow.

MEGHAN. Jesus H. Christ.

MOTHER. Well we can just put it off until you're in shape. I might have to lose a couple pounds too.

MEGHAN. Put it off?

MOTHER. About two years to plan it all, and slim you down.

MEGHAN. We're doing it in three months.

MOTHER. THREE MONTHS? Are you pregnant?

MEGHAN. Actually, yes.

*It's all right, right?*

MEGHAN. Can you see it?

MOTHER. See what?

MEGHAN. My bump.

MOTHER. Good heavens no.

MEGHAN. Good. I'm nervous.

MOTHER. Well, you can't change your dress again.

MEGHAN. I wouldn't have changed it if you hadn't made that comment.

MOTHER. I'm sorry, but your back is not your strongest feature.

MEGHAN. Do you think Steve's the right guy?

MOTHER. Honey, there is no right guy. There are good guys and bad.

MEGHAN. Is he good?

MOTHER. He's marrying you, so yes. But he got you pregnant, so maybe.

MEGHAN. I guess we'll see. At least I got married before Becky.

MOTHER. Yeah! I've already rubbed it in with her mother several times.

MEGHAN. Mom!

MOTHER. Gently. You know, "When Becky gets married, I'm sure she'll do it in spring." You know.

MEGHAN. That's pretty funny. Thanks for coming, Mom. I was worried you'd make good on your threat not to come.

MOTHER. I was pretty upset for a little while.

MEGHAN. Two of the three months.

MOTHER. It flew by.

MEGHAN. In a rage.

MOTHER. But I wouldn't miss this for the world.

MEGHAN. I know. A chance to berate my back.

MOTHER. Among other things.

MEGHAN. Do I look pretty, though, for once?

MOTHER. Steve will be thrilled.

MEGHAN. You think?

MOTHER. Well we already know he likes your looks.

MEGHAN. Mom! But do YOU think I'm pretty?

MOTHER. Mothers don't worry about that sort of thing.

MEGHAN. Of course not.

(*offstage cue*)

MEGHAN. It's time!

MOTHER. Remember: suck it in, don't trip, and don't sneeze on the priest! Jesus will frown on you if you give him a cold.

***miscarriage***

MOTHER. You'll be fine.

MEGHAN. What if I can't have another?

MOTHER. No no, you know I had two before I had you & your brother.

MEGHAN. I know but… you were lucky.

MOTHER. It happens.

MEGHAN. But what if…

MOTHER. What if what?

MEGHAN. What if Steve doesn't love me anymore?

MOTHER. Why?

MEGHAN. Because I couldn't have a baby.

MOTHER. Then I'll snap his wiener off and put it in a jar of Vlasic Kosher Pickles.

MEGHAN. (*giggles*)

MOTHER. When are you going to try again?

MEGHAN. I haven't decided yet.

MOTHER. Well, soon I hope.

MEGHAN. Or maybe never.

MOTHER. Never?

MEGHAN. I don't have to have kids.

MOTHER. You would leave me without a grandchildren?

MEGHAN. What about Brian?

MOTHER. Your brother's never getting married. No, no, you have to have kids.

MEGHAN. I don't have to do anything.

MOTHER. Well, I didn't raise you to have that attitude.

MEGHAN. And thank God you're done raising me. I've put up with this guilt, with this stupid insecurity long enough. I have plenty of problems without you throwing everything you've got at me, for no reason other than to be proud of how much you can still belittle and control me.

MOTHER. I want what's best for you, no matter what.

MEGHAN. Really, well what would be best for me would be if you got out of here. Out of this room, out of my life.

MOTHER. You're so ungrateful.

MEGHAN. Most likely. But at least I'm not like you.

MOTHER. Alright, Meghan, whatever you say.

MEGHAN. Exactly. Get out of here!

***it's my party.***

(*phone conversation*)

MEGHAN. Hello?

MOTHER. Hello, Meghan, it's your mother.

MEGHAN. Ah, so it is.

MOTHER. Well… hello. Your father is retiring. He's having a party. Would you like to come?

MEGHAN. Will the whole family be there?

MOTHER. Yes.

MEGHAN. Then definitely not.

MOTHER. If you change your mind, it's in two weeks at our house. At your house. We'd love to see you.

MEGHAN. That's nice.

MOTHER. Give me a call if you're going to come.

MEGHAN. Don't wait around.

MOTHER. Your brother wants you to meet his wife, I'm sure.

MEGHAN. We had dinner last week.

MOTHER. Oh. Oh, I see. Well then.

MEGHAN. Bye Mom.

*separate, unequal.*

MOTHER. Your nephew is so cute.

MEGHAN. He's great. I really like him.

MOTHER. Do you see him a lot?

MEGHAN. Sure.

MOTHER. I never know these things.

MEGHAN. Brian doesn't tell you?

MOTHER. Oh, he's busy, his family, his work.

MEGHAN. I'm surprised you even told me Dad died.

MOTHER. He would have wanted me too, you know.

MEGHAN. Yes, he was an actual human being.

MOTHER. What if I'd gone first.

MEGHAN. You would have never let that happen.

MOTHER. It took you long enough to tell me you were divorced.

MEGHAN. I've been trying to reorganize my whole life, to clean everything out.

MOTHER. I guess you haven't gotten to your thighs yet.

MEGHAN. Mom.

MOTHER. I'm just saying, if you want a new husband.

MEGHAN. Mom, I don't want another god da – darn husband. How are we back to this conversation already? You haven't seen me in three years.

MOTHER. Nothing changes with you.

MEGHAN. With us.

MOTHER. Well, I'll save it, for your father.

MEGHAN. Ok, fine, me too.

***nothingness.***

(*Mom clicking through TV channels*)

MEGHAN. Hi Mom.

(*nothing*)

MEGHAN. I said, hi.

(*nothing*)

MEGHAN. I figured I should drop by. I was in the neighborhood.

(*nothing*)

MEGHAN. I hope you're not still buying too much jewelry off QVC.

(*nothing*)

MEGHAN. Although it looks like you are.

(*nothing*)

MEGHAN. Well, I'm moving to Seattle. This was our last chance… maybe for a while.

(*nothing*)

MEGHAN. I'm sure Brian told you, though.

MOTHER. Oh lord.

MEGHAN. What?

MOTHER. Let's not talk about any of it at all.

MEGHAN. Ok. Ok, we won't. By the way, I'm taking my prom dress.

MOTHER. Do you still fit into it?

MEGHAN. Yes, as a matter of fact, I do. I was hot and chubby then, and I'm deliciously chubby now. I look effing fabulous in lavender.

MOTHER. Knock yourself out.

MEGHAN. I will. Mom…

MOTHER. Yes?

MEGHAN. I left my new cell number on the fridge.

MOTHER. Ok.

MEGHAN. Ok.

*mother-daughter.*

MOTHER. I figured I should drop by.

MOTHER. So what did…

MEGHAN. 50/50.

MOTHER. Live or die?

MEGHAN. What else? Coke or Pepsi?

MOTHER. Do you want a soda? I'll ring for the nurse. Do they check on you enough.

MEGHAN. They're fine. They're very good. I get attention.

MOTHER. Well you don't have a husband anymore to help you so…

MEGHAN. That's true.

MOTHER. Wait, you're not mad at me for saying that?

MEGHAN. I could be, but… it's true. I wish I had someone.

MOTHER. It's nice. I don't know what I'd do without your father.

MEGHAN. But, well, I'm not that lucky. Sorry.

MOTHER. It's my fault.

MEGHAN. 50/50.

MOTHER. I'm just so worried about you.

MEGHAN. Well, good to know *some* things never change.

MOTHER. It's my only job in this world

MEGHAN. And that's weirdly comforting.

MOTHER. Oh, Meghan.

MEGHAN. I don't know what I should say.

MOTHER. Well, neither do I.

(*silence*)

BOTH. Do you –

MEGHAN. love me?

MOTHER. still love me?

(*another silence*)

MOTHER. You look so thin.

MEGHAN. THANK YOU! Finally.